UGV Path Planning using A* and Dynamic Replanning

By: Grandhe Satya Rohit,

SE24UCSE150

Introduction

This project focuses on path planning for an Unmanned Ground Vehicle (UGV) in both static and dynamic environments. The goal is to find the shortest path from a start node to a goal node on a grid map while avoiding obstacles.

1. A* Algorithm (Static Environment)

The A* (A-Star) algorithm is an informed search algorithm used to find the shortest path in a graph. It combines the advantages of Dijkstra's Algorithm and Greedy Best-First Search.

Evaluation Function:
$f(n) = g(n) + h(n)$
Where:
$g(n)$ = cost from start to current node $h(n)$ =
heuristic estimate (Manhattan distance)

In this project, A* is used when all obstacles are known beforehand (static environment).

2. Dynamic Path Planning

In real-world scenarios, obstacles may appear or disappear dynamically. In such cases, the UGV cannot rely on a precomputed path.

The approach used:
- Compute initial path using A*
- Move step-by-step
- Detect new obstacles
- Recompute path using A*

This process continues until the goal is reached.

3. Algorithm Workflow

1. Initialize grid and obstacle density
2. Take user input for start and goal
3. Run A* to compute initial path
4. Move the robot step-by-step
5. Introduce dynamic obstacles randomly
6. Re-run A* if path is blocked
7. Continue until goal is reached or no path exists

4. Requirements

- Python 3.x - Libraries
used:
* heapq (priority queue)
* random (for obstacle generation)

5. Input and Output

Inputs:
- Grid size
- Start position (row, col)
- Goal position (row, col)
- Obstacle density

Outputs:
- Step-by-step movement
- Final path
- Total steps taken
- Success/Failure message

Output example for UGV:

Output Example for Dynamic Planning:

```
Enter START position:
  Row (0-69): 0
  Col (0-69): 0
Enter GOAL  position:
  Row (0-69): 10
  Col (0-69): 10

Obstacle density:
  1. Low    (~10 %)
  2. Medium (~25 %)
  3. High   (~40 %)
Choose [1-3]: 1

Planning path from (0, 0) to (10, 10) with low obstacle density…
The battlefield environment is represented as a 70 × 70 grid map.

Path found  : 21 steps  (cost = 20)
Start → Goal: (0, 0) → (10, 10)

Display grid? (y/n): y

S * * * * . . # . . . . ...
. . . . * . . . . . . . ...
. # . . * . . . . . . . ...
. . . . * * . . . . . . ...
. . # . . * . . . . . . ...
. . . . . * * . . . . . ...
. . . . . . * . . . . . ...
. . . # . . * * . . . . ...
. . . . . . . * . . . . ...
. . . . . . . * * . . . ...
. . . . . . . . * G . . ...
```

```
Enter grid size (e.g., 20 or 70): 20

Enter START position:
Row (0-19): 4
Col (0-19): 4

Enter GOAL position:
Row (0-19): 13
Col (0-19): 13

Dynamic obstacle density:
1. Low (~1%)
2. Medium (~2%)
3. High (~5%)
Choose [1-3]: 2

Planning in dynamic environment...

Step 1: Moving to (4, 5)
Step 2: Moving to (4, 6)
Step 3: Moving to (5, 6)
Step 4: Moving to (5, 7)
Step 5: Moving to (5, 8)
Step 6: Moving to (5, 7)
Step 7: Moving to (6, 7)
Step 8: Moving to (7, 7)
Step 9: Moving to (7, 8)
Step 10: Moving to (7, 9)
Step 11: Moving to (7, 10)
Step 12: Moving to (7, 11)
Step 13: Moving to (8, 11)
Step 14: Moving to (8, 12)
Step 15: Moving to (9, 12)
Step 16: Moving to (9, 13)
Step 17: Moving to (10, 13)
Step 18: Moving to (10, 12)
Step 19: Moving to (11, 12)
Step 20: Moving to (11, 11)
Step 21: Moving to (12, 11)
❌ No path available!
```

6. Conclusion

The project demonstrates how A* efficiently solves static path planning problems, and how dynamic replanning enables navigation in uncertain environments. Such techniques are widely used in robotics, autonomous vehicles, and military applications.